

THE COMPACT PLAYBOOK

Claude Chat, end to end.

The conversation interface at claude.ai — where you think things through, draft, analyse, and learn.

15 sections

plain, practical

copy-paste prompts

SECTION 01

What Claude Chat is

Claude Chat is the conversation interface at claude.ai — available on web, mobile, and desktop. It's where you come to think things through, get things drafted, understand something complicated, work through a problem, or produce a polished piece of writing. No installation required. Open a browser or the app, start typing.

Chat is Claude's home base. Everything else Anthropic has built — Cowork, Claude Code, Claude for Excel, Claude for PowerPoint — is specialised for a specific surface or task type. Chat handles everything that doesn't need a dedicated tool: analysis, writing, learning, planning, ideation, coding help, research, and conversation.

Who Chat is built for

Chat is for anyone who needs to think, write, or understand something — which is to say it's for everyone.

- Students — understanding concepts, getting feedback on writing, preparing for exams
- Writers and editors — drafting, rewriting, editing, finding the right tone
- Professionals — preparing for meetings, structuring arguments, working through decisions
- Researchers and analysts — summarising sources, sense-checking logic, exploring a topic
- Developers — asking questions, debugging code, understanding documentation

- Managers and founders – thinking on paper, preparing presentations, drafting comms
- Anyone curious – learning a new subject, exploring ideas, getting straight answers

Tip. No technical background required. No installation. If you can type a question, you can get value from Chat. What it produces – Polished drafts – emails, essays, reports, proposals, scripts, posts – Explanations – complex subjects broken down clearly at any level – Analysis – structured thinking on decisions, data, documents, or arguments – Code – working scripts, functions, and debugging help across most languages – Research reports – multi-source synthesis with cited findings (Research mode) – Artifacts – live documents, charts, diagrams, visualisations, and mini apps in the chat window – Answers – with current web search when the topic requires up-to-date information

SECTION 02

Chat vs Cowork vs Claude Code

Anthropic has three main ways of working with Claude. Picking the right one for the job saves a lot of friction.

	CHAT	COWORK	CLAUDE CODE
Best for	Questions, writing, analysis, research, brainstorming	Multi-step knowledge work with files and outputs	Codebases, engineering tasks, real shipped code
Audience	Everyone	Non-developers and developers alike	Developers (and increasingly non-engineers)
File access	Upload files into the conversation	Yes – reads and writes your local files	Yes – full project access on your machine
Runs how long?	One turn at a time	Long-running, multi-step	Long-running, multi-step, parallel agents
Where it lives	Web, mobile, desktop	Desktop app only (Mac, Windows)	Terminal, IDE, desktop, web, Slack, CI
Mental model	Asking a brilliant colleague a question	Handing a project to an assistant	Pairing with a senior engineer

A simple rule

- Need an answer, a draft, or a conversation? → Chat → Need work done on your files?
- Cowork → Need code shipped? → Claude Code

SECTION 03

Getting access

No setup required

Claude Chat runs in any modern browser and on iOS and Android. Go to claude.ai, create a free account, and you're in. No installation, no terminal, no configuration.

Plans at a glance

PLAN	PRICE	WHAT YOU GET
Free	No cost	Access to Claude Sonnet. Enough to explore most of Chat’s core features. Tighter message limits. No Research mode.
Pro	\$20/month	All models including Opus (the most capable). Much higher message limits. Research mode. Projects. Web search. Artifacts.
Max	\$100+/month	5–20x higher usage limits than Pro. Same features. Best for people who use Claude as a primary work tool every day.
Team	\$30/user/month	Pro features for teams. Shared Projects. Admin controls. Memory across the org. Minimum 5 seats.
Enterprise	Custom	Custom usage, SSO, audit logs, compliance controls, organisation-wide admin. Contact Anthropic sales.

Where to access Claude Chat

- Web: claude.ai — full feature set including web search, Research mode, Projects, and Artifacts
- iOS and Android: Claude app — the same Chat features in your pocket, with voice input
- Claude Desktop app: download from claude.com/download — Chat tab alongside Cowork. Slightly richer interface for

sustained work sessions.

SECTION 04

The interface in 30 seconds

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT IT DOES
Chat window (centre)	Where the conversation lives. Claude's responses appear here with inline citations when it uses web sources.
Input box (bottom)	Where you type. Supports multi-line text, pasted content, and file uploads.
Model selector (top left)	Switch between Sonnet, Opus, and Haiku mid-conversation.
Web search toggle (bottom left)	Turns on real-time web access. On by default on paid plans.
Research button (bottom left)	Puts Claude into Research mode — multi-source agentic investigation with citations. Paid plans only.

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT IT DOES
Artifacts panel (right side)	Live preview of any document, chart, diagram, or interactive tool Claude generates.
Projects (left sidebar)	Saved workspaces with persistent files, instructions, and memory across conversations.
Settings → Capabilities	Where you manage memory, search preferences, and connected tools.
Ghost icon (top right)	Starts an incognito chat — not saved to history, not used for memory.

SECTION 05

The 5-step flow

Every useful Chat session follows the same pattern. Once you've done it a few times, it becomes automatic.

01 Give Claude the right context upfront

A conversation is only as good as its starting context. Before asking your question, give Claude what it needs to answer well: who you are, what you're working on, and what you want the output to do.

'Weak:' Write an email about the project. 'Strong:' I'm a product manager at a B2B SaaS company. Write an email to our enterprise customers explaining a 2-week delay to the Q3 launch. Tone: honest and reassuring, not corporate. Under 200 words.

02 Ask your question or give your task

You can ask a direct question, give a writing task, paste in a document for analysis, describe a problem, or upload a file. Claude handles all of these from the same input box. If you need current information, make sure web search is toggled on.

03 Read the response before reacting

Read Claude's response before immediately asking for changes. Often a quick re-read shows the answer you needed was already there. If something is off, identify exactly what – wrong tone, missing a point, too long, wrong format – and give that specific feedback.

04 Iterate

The best output rarely comes on the first turn. Push:

'Shorter. Cut it to 5 bullet points.' 'Too formal. Rewrite in plain language.' 'The third paragraph is weak – expand it with a concrete example.' 'Now give me three alternative headlines for this.'

05 Copy, save, or turn it into an Artifact

When you're happy with the output, copy it, or ask Claude to generate it as an Artifact — a live version in the panel on the right that you can download, share, or keep refining.

SECTION 06

Projects — persistent workspaces

Projects are saved workspaces inside Chat that give Claude persistent context across every conversation in that project. You upload files once, write instructions once, and every new chat inside that project starts with all of it already loaded.

When to use a Project vs a standalone chat

USE A STANDALONE CHAT WHEN...	USE A PROJECT WHEN...
One-off question or task	Recurring work on the same topic or client
No need to remember anything next time	You keep re-explaining the same context
Quick draft or analysis	Ongoing writing, research, or planning that spans many sessions
No files needed	You have reference docs Claude should always know about

What lives in a Project

- Files you upload (PDFs, Word docs, spreadsheets, code files, images)
- Custom instructions – Claude's standing brief for all chats in this project
- Conversation history – all chats in the project, searchable
- Project memory – a separate memory space distinct from your general chat memory

Example custom instructions for a Project

SAMPLE CUSTOM INSTRUCTIONS

I'm a freelance copywriter working on content for Acme Corp, a B2B logistics company.

Tone: direct, confident, never corporate jargon

Audience: operations managers and supply chain leads

Default output: plain prose, no headers unless asked

Brand voice: practical, straightforward, quietly expert

Always ask if you're unsure of the word count I need

How to create a Project

- Click Projects in the left sidebar
- Click New Project and give it a name
- Add files and custom instructions in the project settings
- Start a new chat inside the project — it opens with full context already loaded

Note. Free plan users can create up to five Projects. Pro and above get unlimited Projects.

SECTION 07

Memory

Claude Chat remembers context across conversations. You don't have to re-introduce yourself or re-explain your preferences every session.

How memory works

Every 24 hours, Claude generates a synthesis of your recent standalone chat history and uses it as background context for new conversations. Memory is separate per Project — what you do in one project doesn't bleed into another or into your general chats.

What Claude remembers

- Your name and role
- Your communication preferences (tone, format, length)
- Your writing style when it has seen enough of your work
- Ongoing projects and recurring topics you discuss
- Preferences you've stated explicitly — "I prefer bullet points" or "use UK English"

How to manage memory

- View it: Settings → Capabilities → Memory — read exactly what Claude knows about you
- Edit it: correct anything wrong directly in the memory panel
- Pause it: Claude keeps existing memories but stops making new ones
- Reset it: permanently deletes all memories including project memories. Cannot be undone.
- Incognito chat: click the ghost icon (top right) to open a chat that isn't saved or added to memory at all

Tip. Go to Settings → Capabilities → Memory right now and read what Claude already knows about you. Edit anything wrong. Add things it should know. The more accurate your memory profile, the less you repeat yourself.

SECTION 08

Web search and Research mode

By default, Claude's responses draw on its training. When you need current information — recent events, live prices, the latest product release, up-to-date statistics — turn on web search or Research mode.

Web search

When enabled, Claude searches the web in real time and weaves the results into its response with inline citations. Best for quick fact-checking, current events, recent company news, or any question where recency matters.

- How to turn it on: click the web search toggle (bottom left of the chat input). On by default on paid plans.
- When to use it: any question that could have changed in the last few months — stock prices, news, product launches, recent research, current policy.
- When to turn it off: pure writing tasks, reasoning from uploaded documents, analysis where you control all the sources.

Research mode (paid plans)

Research mode is the deep version. Instead of a single search, Claude plans a multi-step investigation, runs parallel searches, evaluates what it finds, and compiles a structured report with cited sources. It uses extended thinking automatically to plan its search strategy before writing anything.

- How to turn it on: click the Research button (bottom left). It turns blue when active. Web search must be on for Research to

work.

- How long it takes: 5 to 15 minutes for a standard query. Up to 45 minutes for complex investigations. You don't need to

keep the tab open — it runs in the background.

- When to use it: market analysis, competitive research, literature review, technology evaluation, industry overviews,

fact-checking a specific claim across multiple sources.

- When not to use it: quick factual questions (web search is faster), tasks that don't need current information, pure writing

tasks. Research mode uses your message credits faster than standard chat.

Note. Research mode is available on Pro, Max, Team, and Enterprise plans. Not available on Free.

SECTION 09

Artifacts

When Claude generates something that stands on its own as a document or interactive object, it can render it as an Artifact in a live panel alongside the conversation. Instead of a wall of text you have to copy-paste, you get a live preview you can interact with, refine, and download.

What Claude can produce as an Artifact

- Markdown documents: reports, essays, memos, guides — formatted and readable
- HTML pages: landing pages, formatted documents, web-ready layouts
- React components: interactive tools, dashboards, calculators, forms
- Charts and data visualisations: bar charts, line charts, scatter plots rendered live from your data
- SVG diagrams: flowcharts, architecture diagrams, timelines, illustrations
- Mermaid diagrams: flowcharts, sequence diagrams, entity relationship diagrams
- Code files: scripts and modules you can copy or download directly

Working with an Artifact

- Ask for changes by continuing the conversation — Claude updates the Artifact in place
- Click the Artifact to interact with live elements (calculators, forms, charts)
- Copy or download the output from the Artifact panel
- Ask Claude to “turn this into an Artifact” on any response to render it live

Tip. Artifacts are free on all plans including Free.

SECTION 10

Connectors

Connectors link Claude Chat to external tools and data sources. With them, Claude can pull from your Google Drive, scan your Gmail, check your calendar, and more — all within the chat interface.

Available connectors

- Google Workspace (Docs, Gmail, Calendar): Claude can search your emails, read your documents, and see your

calendar commitments. Pull meeting notes from last week, find action items from email threads, summarise a document without uploading it.

- MCP connectors: third-party integrations built on the Model Context Protocol — Jira, Slack, Notion, GitHub, and more.

Browse available connectors at claude.ai and connect the ones that fit your workflow.

How to connect

- Go to Settings → Integrations (or the connectors section in the left sidebar)
- Authenticate the service you want to connect
- Back in chat, Claude uses connected sources when relevant — or ask it to explicitly

Note. Connectors get read (and sometimes write) access to your data. Review what each connector can access before enabling it. For Google Workspace on Team and Enterprise, your admin must enable it org-wide first.

SECTION 11

How to write prompts that work

Most disappointing results come from vague prompts. Claude needs to know what you want, why you want it, and what good looks like. Use this formula:

PROMPT FORMULA

[Your role or context] + [What you want] + [Format or constraints] + [Audience or purpose]

Weak vs strong prompts

TASK	WEAK	STRONG
Email	Write an email about the delay.	I'm a PM at a SaaS company. Write a 150-word email to enterprise clients explaining a 2-week delay to our Q3 launch. Tone: honest and reassuring, not corporate.
Analysis	What do you think of this strategy?	I'm a consultant. Here's a 3-page strategy doc [paste]. What are the 3 biggest logical gaps? Be direct — I'd rather hear hard truths than polite agreement.
Summary	Summarise this.	Summarise this 10-page contract for a non-lawyer. Lead with the 5 most important points. Flag anything unusual or risky. One paragraph per point.

TASK	WEAK	STRONG
Research	Tell me about the EV market.	I'm writing a board briefing. Research the global EV market — growth rate, top 5 players by market share, key regulatory changes in the last 12 months, and the 3 biggest risks to adoption.
Writing	Write a blog post about productivity.	Write a 600-word blog post for startup founders on why most productivity advice backfires. First-person voice. Counterintuitive angle. No generic tips. End with one specific thing to try today.

Things to mention when they apply

- Your role and your reader's role
- Tone (direct, formal, casual, technical, friendly, sceptical)
- Format (bullet points, numbered list, prose, table, email format)
- Length (word count, number of items, one paragraph)
- What to avoid (jargon, hedging, filler phrases, starting with "Certainly!")
- What you're going to do with the output ("I'll post this on LinkedIn", "this goes to the board")

Push back on the first response

Claude's first response is a starting point, not a final answer. The best output usually needs a few turns: 'Too long. Cut by half.' 'The tone is still too formal. Make it sound like a human wrote it.' 'Good structure but the intro is weak. Rewrite just that part.' 'Give me three alternative versions of the headline.' 'You're hedging too much. Say what you actually think.'

SECTION 12

Ten use cases with starter prompts

Copy, adapt, paste into Claude Chat. Pick the one closest to your real work first.

1. Write or rewrite anything

FOR anyone who writes as part of their job — which is most people

STARTER PROMPT

I need to send a difficult email to a client who is unhappy about a missed deadline.
Context: The delay was partly our fault and partly caused by slow sign-off on their side.
Goal: Acknowledge what's ours, note (diplomatically) the shared responsibility, and propose a revised timeline. Tone: professional, human, not defensive. Under 200 words.

2 Understand something complicated

FOR students, professionals entering a new domain, anyone learning on the job

STARTER PROMPT

Explain transformer architecture to me like I'm a software engineer who has never worked in ML. I understand attention mechanisms at a high level but I've never trained a model. Keep it conceptual — I want to understand why it works, not implement it. Use an analogy if one helps, but only if it's actually accurate.

3 Research a topic with current sources

FOR analysts, strategists, students, anyone making a decision that depends on current information

STARTER PROMPT

[Turn on Research mode before sending this]

I'm preparing a briefing for our leadership team on the competitive landscape in AI-powered legal research tools. Cover: the top 5 players and their positioning, key differentiators, recent funding or M&A activity, and what's driving adoption in large law firms right now. Cite your sources. Format as a structured report.

4 Analyse a document

FOR anyone who receives dense material and needs to make sense of it fast

STARTER PROMPT

[Upload the document or paste the content, then send:]

Read this contract and give me a one-page summary for a non-lawyer. Cover: parties, key obligations on both sides, payment terms, termination clauses, liability limits, and anything unusual or aggressive. Flag the top 3 things I should pay attention to before signing.

5 Prepare for a meeting or presentation

FOR managers, founders, consultants — anyone going into a high-stakes conversation

STARTER PROMPT

I have a 30-minute meeting tomorrow with a potential enterprise client (CFO of a 2,000-person manufacturing company). They've seen our demo and have concerns about integration complexity. Help me prepare:

1. The 3 most likely objections and how to address them
2. 5 questions I should ask to understand their setup
3. The single most important thing to leave them believing

6 Think through a decision

FOR anyone stuck between options and wanting structured help thinking it through

STARTER PROMPT

I'm deciding whether to hire a full-time marketing manager or work with a fractional CMO for the next 12 months. We're a 25-person B2B SaaS company, Series A, 3Cr ARR. Don't just list pros and cons — tell me what the decision actually hinges on and what questions I should answer before choosing.

7 Get feedback on your writing

FOR writers, students, anyone who needs an honest outside eye before publishing or submitting

STARTER PROMPT

[Paste your writing, then send:]

Give me direct feedback on this piece. I'm looking for:

- Is the argument actually convincing? Where does it weaken?
- Is there anything that would make a reader stop trusting me?
- What's the weakest sentence? What's the strongest?
- What should I cut?

Be honest. I'd rather hear problems now than after I publish.

8 Get help with code

FOR developers, students learning to code, non-engineers writing scripts

STARTER PROMPT

I'm getting this error in my Python script and can't figure out why:

[paste the error message]

Here's the relevant code:

[paste the code]

What's causing it? Explain the root cause before giving me the fix, so I actually understand what went wrong.

9 Plan a project or roadmap

FOR PMs, founders, team leads — anyone who needs structure before diving into execution

STARTER PROMPT

I'm planning a rebrand for a 10-year-old B2B professional services firm. We want to launch in 6 months. I have a designer, a copywriter, and a web developer. Give me a realistic project plan — phases, key milestones, dependencies, and the 3 most common places projects like this fall apart. Don't pad it out — I want the thinking, not a template.

10 Learn something through conversation

FOR students, career changers, professionals learning a new domain

STARTER PROMPT

I want to understand options trading well enough to follow the strategies our CFO discusses in board calls. I know basic finance but have no derivatives background. Teach me conversationally — ask me questions to check my understanding as you go. Start with: what problem does an option actually solve, and who uses them?

SECTION 13

Pro tips

Front-load the context, not the request

The single biggest improvement most people make is putting context before the task, not after. Who you are, what you're working on, what the output needs to do — all of that should come before the ask.

Tell Claude who it's writing for

"Write a summary of this report" produces a generic summary. "Write a summary of this report for a non-technical VP who will present it to the board in 10 minutes" produces something that actually fits the situation.

Ask for what you don't want as well as what you do

"Concise" means different things to everyone. "No longer than 150 words, no bullet points, no jargon" leaves no ambiguity. Negative constraints are often the most useful ones.

Use Projects for anything you'll do more than once

If you keep starting new chats and re-explaining the same context, you need a Project. It takes 5 minutes to set up and saves time every session after that.

Go to Settings → Memory and read what Claude knows

Most users never look at this. The ones who do get better results every session because they've corrected wrong assumptions and added context Claude should have. Five minutes, once.

Use Research mode as a thinking partner, not just a search engine. The best Research prompts don't just ask "what is X" — they ask Claude to investigate, compare, synthesise, and give a perspective. "Research the state of X and tell me what you'd recommend to a founder making this decision" beats "tell me about X" every time.

Ask Claude to push back

Claude defaults to helpful. If you want rigorous challenge — an argument stress-tested, a plan critiqued — say so explicitly. "Steelman the strongest objection to this plan" or "Tell me why this strategy is probably wrong" produces something different from a polite review.

Use incognito chat when you don't want memory

For anything sensitive or that you simply don't want feeding into your memory profile, click the ghost icon and use an incognito chat. It's not saved, it doesn't update memory, and it's not used for training.

Iterate, don't restart

When a response misses the mark, most people start a new chat. That throws away the context Claude has built up. Keep the conversation going – tell Claude exactly what’s wrong and ask for a revised version. You’ll get there faster than starting over.

Use Claude as a thought partner, not just an output machine

The conversations that produce the best work often start with thinking out loud. “Here’s the problem I’m trying to solve...” or “I keep going back and forth on this decision...” — Claude is good at helping you clarify what you actually want, not just producing what you literally asked for.

SECTION 14

Troubleshooting

PROBLEM	WHAT TO DO
Hitting message limits	Claude Chat is usage-limited on all plans. For heavy daily use, upgrade from Pro to Max (5–20x higher limits). For lighter limits, switch to Haiku for simple tasks — it uses fewer credits.
Response is too generic	The prompt is almost always too vague. Add your role, your reader, the purpose, the tone, and the format. The more specific the brief, the more specific the output.
Claude keeps hedging and adding disclaimers	“Give me a direct answer without caveats or disclaimers” is a perfectly valid instruction and it works.

PROBLEM	WHAT TO DO
Research mode not showing up	Research is only available on paid plans. If you're on a paid plan and don't see it, make sure web search is toggled on first — Research requires web search to be active.
Artifact didn't appear	Ask explicitly: "Turn this into an Artifact." Some outputs are too short or conversational to become Artifacts automatically.
Claude doesn't remember my preferences	Check Settings → Capabilities → Memory to confirm memory is on. If it's paused or reset, that's why. For persistent context, use a Project rather than standalone chats.
Web search results are wrong or outdated	Always check the cited source directly for high-stakes factual claims. The inline citations are there for exactly this reason.

PROBLEM	WHAT TO DO
Wrong direction completely	Don't nudge a response that's fundamentally wrong. Say: "Forget that. Let me restate what I need: [clear description]." Starting the steering over is faster than small corrections on a bad foundation.
Google Workspace connector not pulling my	For Team and Enterprise, your admin needs to enable Google Workspace access org-wide first.
docs	For individual users, go to Settings → Integrations and check that your Google account is connected.

SECTION 15

Your first 30 minutes

If you've never properly used Claude Chat, here's the fastest path to feeling competent. Block 30 minutes.

Minute 0–5 Set up your account

- Go to claude.ai and sign in or create an account
- If you're on a paid plan, go to Settings → Capabilities → Memory and read what Claude already knows about you. Edit

anything wrong.

- Confirm web search is toggled on (toggle at the bottom left of the chat input)

Minute 5–10 Create your first Project

- Pick one area of work you keep coming back to. Create a Project for it:
- Click Projects in the sidebar → New Project
- Name it something specific
- Write 5–6 lines of custom instructions: your role, your tone preferences, what Claude should know about this work
- Upload one or two key reference documents if you have them

Minute 10–20

Run three real tasks

- Inside your new Project, run three quick tasks that reflect actual work you'd normally do:
- A writing task — a draft, a rewrite, or a summary of something you're working on
- An analysis — paste a document or description and ask Claude to find the gaps or key points
- A question — something you'd normally Google, but where you want synthesis, not ten links
- Push back on at least one response. Ask for a shorter version, a different tone, or an alternative.

Minute 20–25

Try Research mode

- Enable Research mode and send a question that depends on current information — a competitor, a market, a technology

trend relevant to your work. Come back in 10 minutes and read what it found.

Minute 25–30

Ask for an Artifact

- Ask Claude to turn one of your outputs into an Artifact — a formatted document, a chart, or a diagram. See what it looks like

in the live panel.

Tip. That's it. You now have a Project with context, a memory profile that's accurate, and a real feel for the tool. Everything else is practice. Quick Reference Card THE MENTAL MODEL THE TOGGLE CHEAT SHEET Chat = ask, write, think, and research through conversation Web search on: current information, live facts, recent news Cowork = hand off a file-based task, get finished work Research mode on: multi-source investigation, market analysis, Claude Code = pair with a senior engineer on a codebase cited reports Ghost icon (incognito): sensitive topics, no history, no memory THE 5-STEP FLOW update – Give Claude the right context upfront Projects: recurring work, persistent context, uploaded files that – Ask your question or give your task should always be available – Read the response before reacting – Iterate with specific feedback HIGHEST-LEVERAGE SETUP STEPS – Copy, save, or turn it into an Artifact – Read and correct your memory (Settings → Capabilities → Memory) PROMPT FORMULA – Create a Project for your most frequent use case (5 minutes, [Your role / context] + [What you want] every session benefits) + [Format or constraints] + [Audience or purpose] – Write specific prompts: role + task + format + constraints + audience – Push back on responses – iterate until you have what you actually need